

Employee Assistance Program Guide

What the EAP Covers

The Contoso Employee Assistance Program (EAP) provides up to 6 free confidential counseling sessions per issue, per year, for employees and their household members. Sessions can be used for a range of concerns including stress, grief, relationship issues, and substance use, and a new 6-session allotment is available for each distinct issue, not a single shared pool across all concerns.

Additional Services

The EAP also offers free legal consultations (up to 1 hour per matter), financial planning sessions, and childcare/eldercare referral services, all administered by the same third-party provider as the counseling benefit, so a single phone call can connect an employee to whichever of these services fits their situation.

How to Access

Call the EAP support line at 1-800-555-0199, available 24/7, or visit the EAP portal linked from the Contoso benefits page. All contact is confidential and not shared with Contoso Corp, including whether a given employee has used the service at all — Contoso Corp only ever sees aggregate, anonymized utilization statistics, never individual usage records.

Crisis Support

For an immediate mental health crisis, the EAP line offers a dedicated crisis option available at the same number, staffed by licensed clinicians who can also connect the caller to local emergency services if needed. This crisis option does not count against the standard 6-session annual allotment described above.

Managers who become aware an employee may be in crisis are encouraged, but not required, to share the EAP crisis number directly; managers are never expected to assess or manage a mental health crisis themselves, and doing so is explicitly discouraged in favor of connecting the employee to the trained clinicians on the EAP line.

Manager Referrals

A manager who is concerned about an employee's wellbeing based on observable workplace performance (not a diagnosis, which managers are not qualified to make) may suggest the employee consider the EAP; this suggestion must never be framed as a condition of continued employment, and

using it that way is itself a policy violation.

Household Member Eligibility

Household members eligible for EAP services include a spouse or domestic partner and any dependent living in the employee's home, including college-age dependents living away for school; the household member does not need to be enrolled in Contoso Corp's health insurance to be eligible for the EAP, since the two benefits are administered separately.

Frequently Asked Questions

Will using the EAP show up anywhere in my personnel file? No — EAP usage is confidential and is never recorded in an employee's personnel file or shared with a manager; only aggregate, anonymized utilization statistics across the whole company are ever shared with Contoso Corp.

Can I use the EAP for a work-related stress issue, or only personal matters? Work-related stress, conflict with a colleague, and burnout are all explicitly within scope for EAP counseling; the EAP is not limited to personal or family matters.

Roles and Responsibilities

The third-party EAP provider delivers counseling and referral services directly and independently of Contoso Corp. HR communicates the benefit's existence and how to access it. Managers may suggest the EAP to a struggling employee but are never responsible for assessing or managing a mental health situation themselves.

In-Person and Virtual Session Options

EAP counseling sessions are available both virtually (video or phone) and in person through the provider's local network of clinicians, depending on employee preference and local availability; virtual sessions are generally available faster than in-person appointments and are equally covered under the same 6-session allotment.

Relationship to Short-Term Disability

The EAP is not a substitute for short-term disability coverage, which provides income replacement during an extended medical leave including for a mental health condition; an employee whose counseling needs extend beyond what the EAP's 6 free sessions can address should discuss short-term disability and continued treatment options with HR, who can explain how the two benefits work together.